

Captures can hide a negative sum

Chess Math

THE IDEA

Winning the first piece does not mean winning the trade. A common calculation mistake is to count an enemy rook you capture and forget that your queen must then be recaptured. Write a gain-and-loss ledger mentally.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Your queen takes a rook worth 5, and a pawn then takes your queen worth 9. If there is no further gain, the net result is $5-9=-4$. The phrase 'I won a rook' describes only half the transaction.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What if a bishop worth 3 captures that rook and is recaptured?

ANSWER AND REASONING

The balance is $5-3=+2$. Both sequences capture the same rook, yet their costs differ greatly. That is why the order and identity of attackers matter.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Record the cost of the capturing piece.